Pest & Problem “What Did That?” Worksheet

A friendly getting-started guide

Something ate your leaves overnight and you don't know what. That's okay — nobody starts out knowing. This worksheet turns mystery damage into detective notes: what you saw, when, where, and what you tried.

How to use it

1. **Describe the damage, not the culprit.** Holes in leaves? Chewed stems? White fuzz? Sticky residue? Lines carved into tunnels inside leaves? Each pattern points to a different suspect.
2. **Look at the timing.** Slugs and snails work at night and leave shiny trails. Caterpillars feed in daytime shade. Cutworms fell seedlings at the soil line.
3. **Sketch or describe what you find** — the bug itself, egg clusters on leaf undersides, droppings, or the damage pattern.
4. **Try the gentlest fix first:** hand-picking, a strong spray of water, row cover, or soapy water for aphids. Log what you did and whether it worked.

Beginner tip: Not every bug is a bad bug. Ladybugs, lacewings, bees, and ground beetles are on your side. Identify before you squish.

Common beginner mysteries: ragged holes at night = slugs or caterpillars; seedlings cut off at soil level = cutworms; curly distorted leaves = aphids; brown tunnels inside leaves = leafminers.

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Date spotted: _____ **Crop affected:** _____ **Bed / location:** _____

1. What does the damage look like?

Check all that apply:

☐ Holes in leaves ☐ Leaves skeletonized ☐ Seedling cut at soil line ☐ Curled / distorted leaves
☐ White spots or fuzz ☐ Sticky residue ☐ Trails or slime marks ☐ Tunnels inside leaves
☐ Wilting with no visible cause ☐ Chewed fruit ☐ Yellowing leaves ☐ Other: _____

2. When and where did you notice it?

Time of day: _____ Weather lately: _____ Only one plant or spreading? _____

3. Sketch or describe what you saw

4. My best guess at the culprit

5. What I tried, and whether it worked

WHAT I TRIED	DATE	WORKED?	NOTES

One mystery per copy of this sheet — the archive of solved cases is half the fun.